

7 Mailing lists

Mailing lists are wonderful things when they work well and almost everyone subscribes to one on the Internet. But a poorly designed mailing list can make the sender and the sender's company look like amateurs and even lead to more serious issues.

Take the case of the drug manufacturing giant Eli Lilly, which made the headlines last year when it accidentally revealed the names of 600 users of its prescription drugs to other users. The company had set up an e-mail service to send reminder messages to individual users taking its drugs for serious diseases. In June last year, Lilly shut down the reminder service and sent a message to all the users informing them of this. However, confidential patient information was released when the sender put all the patients' names in the 'To:' field. Not only did the company get a lot of bad press, but also matters were made worse when the American Civil Liberties Union asked the US Federal Trade Commission to investigate.



Workaround: Use specialised mailing list software, even for what seem like one-time bulk messages. All mailing list software allow one-way lists; this will help prevent recipients from seeing each other's addresses and responses.

8 Set up a group

Take the case of this assistant who sent out a proposal, complete with quotation, to a client with a CC to everybody who'd been working on that client's account. The bloopers? Included in the CC was an ex-colleague who now worked for a rival firm. So now the competition knew who their clients were and how much to charge!

This is a common mistake most people make while using groups—they forget to check whether all the addresses in the list are relevant or not. So many times e-mails are blithely sent to a group which is never updated and mail continues to go to people who've left or are no longer working on that project.



Workaround: Check the 'To:' Field. Check groups on a regular basis and update the entries.

HOW TO WRITE ERROR-FREE E-MAIL

Rule 1: Always check the 'To:' field before you click 'Send'.

Rule 2: Don't be hasty in clicking on 'Send'. Put the e-mail aside and then reread it after sometime. This will help you tone down the message if you've written the mail in an angry mood, and weed out any inappropriate content.

Rule 3: Save your draft e-mail on a floppy or even as a word file on your hard drive. It is very easy to accidentally send an e-mail you are still working on if it is saved in the Drafts

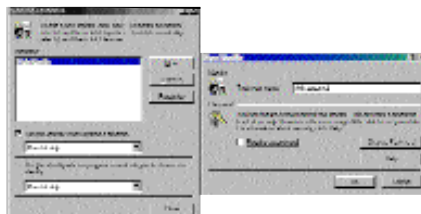
folder in Outlook Express.

Rule 4: Think before you commit anything to electronic mail. That joke or off-the-cuff remark about a colleague could come back and hit you in the face when you least expect it.

Rule 5: Don't say on e-mail what you wouldn't say in person. It is very easy to misconstrue comments in an e-mail message. The reader cannot see your body language, or hear the tone of your voice to judge whether you mean that comment as a joke or as a caustic remark.

9 All accounted for?

We all check personal e-mail from the office and might even use our office e-mail IDs for sending personal mails. After all, it's more convenient to access all your mail from one place. We know of an aspiring designer who wanted to earn some extra money by moonlighting as a freelancer. But he started using the e-mail system in the office to correspond with his client. The only problem was that the day he was away to work on his freelance assignment, his boss went through his e-mail account in search of some information relating to another project he was



Create multiple identities to avoid confusion

working on. Needless to say, he now devotes all his time to freelancing.

Confusion could also follow when you start giving out your personal account for official mail because the office mail server is temporarily on the blink. Before you realise it, your personal account is the repository of all your office information. You leave office and continue to get mail in your personal account. Also consider the amount of amusement you would cause if by mistake you end up sending a mail to your associate in the branch office from an address that reads mrsexycool@hotmail.com!

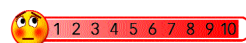


Workaround: Use different identities for office and personal accounts.

To set up a new mail identity in Outlook Express click on **File > Identities > Add New Identity** and type the name for your new identity. Now click 'Yes' to switch over to your new identity. You will be prompted to enter your screen name and e-mail address details. After you are done with that, click on **File > Identities > Manage Identities**. Select the new Identity you've set up for your personal mail and click on 'Properties'. Now tick 'Ask me for a password when I start' and enter a password. Your e-mail client will now ask you for a password whenever you want to use this identity. You can switch between your two identities by clicking on **File > Switch Identity**.

10 Watch what you delete

And finally we come to the mother of all blunders, the most irredeemable goof that we could possibly do. Yes, you guessed it, it's when we delete an e-mail or mailbox folder only to realise that we've accidentally wiped clean something important and there's no way to get it back from the nether space of our hard disk. Well, it happens to the best of us, but that's not going to stop us from shouting out "LOSER"!



Workaround: Look before you click to delete and name the subfolders in your Inbox intelligently so that there is little room for error.

You can prevent Outlook Express from cleaning up your Deleted Items folder by going to **Tools > Options > Maintenance** and deselecting the 'Empty messages from Deleted Items on exit' tick box.

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